

How to Check a Mining Claim in 10 Minutes

A plain-English walkthrough of the BLM's Mineral & Land Records System, so you never pan on someone else's claim by accident.

"A claim marker is a man's front door. You knock, you don't walk in." — Grandpa Ezra

WHY THIS MATTERS

Public land isn't always open ground

Most BLM land and national forest is open to casual panning. But a lot of the good creeks in the West are covered by **unpatented mining claims**. A claim gives the holder the rights to the minerals, even though the land itself stays public. You can usually still hike, camp and fish there. You cannot take their gold.

Panning on an active claim without permission is called **claim jumping**. It's the fastest way to make enemies at a creek, and it can get you cited. The good news: checking takes about ten minutes once you know the steps.

What you need

- ☐ The spot you want to pan, found on a map (Google Maps or a topo app is fine)
- ☐ A computer or phone with internet
- ☐ Ten minutes and a notebook, or your Sample Log page from the workbook

Step 1. Get the legal description of your spot

Western public land is mapped on a grid called the **Public Land Survey System**. Every spot has an address made of four parts, written as **MTRS**:

PART	WHAT IT MEANS	EXAMPLE
Meridian	The survey baseline for your region, as a two-digit code	21 (Mount Diablo, used in Nevada and much of California)
Township	A 6×6 mile square, counted north or south	0450N = Township 45 North
Range	Its position east or west	0700E = Range 70 East
Section	One of the 36 one-mile squares inside the township	032 = Section 32

Easiest way to find it: open a free PLSS viewer or a topo app that shows "Township/Range" lines (many hunting and offroad map apps do), tap your creek, and copy the township, range and section. The BLM also suggests reading it from a USGS topo map. Write it down. You'll also want the **quarter section** (NE, NW, SE or SW) if you can see it.

Step 2. Open MLRS

Go to <https://mlrs.blm.gov>. This is the BLM's official, free public database. It replaced the older LR2000 system in 2021. If it asks why you're visiting, choose **Mining Claims Research**.

Step 3. Run the "Mining Claims – Geographic Report"

1. Open the public reports and choose **Mining Claims – Geographic Report**.
2. Set the **Admin State** to the state your creek is in. (Exception: Montana's BLM office also handles North and South Dakota, so use MT for those.)
3. Enter the **Meridian Township Range Section**. The format is padded with zeros, for example 21 0450N 0700E 032. Hover over the field for the exact format.
4. Set the case disposition to **Active**.
5. Add your quarter section if you know it, then run the report.

Step 4. Read the result

YOU SEE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
No active claims	No one holds a current claim in that section	Good sign. Still check Step 5, then go pan.
One or more ACTIVE claims	Someone holds mineral rights somewhere in that section	Find out exactly where (Step 6), or pick another section.
Only CLOSED claims	Old claims that lapsed	Treated like no claim. A closed claim is a hint that someone once found gold there.

Important: MLRS tells you a claim exists in the section. It does **not** draw the exact boundary. A section is a square mile, and a claim might cover only a corner of it. Lode claims can also cross section lines, so check the neighboring sections too.

Step 5. Make sure the land is open at all

Some public land is closed to prospecting no matter what MLRS says:

- **National parks:** collecting is generally not allowed.
- **Wilderness areas and withdrawn land:** often closed to new mineral activity.
- **Private land:** you always need the owner's permission. Land status maps from the BLM or your county show who owns what.

The quickest check is a phone call to the local **BLM field office** or **Forest Service ranger district**. They answer this question every day.

Step 6. If there is a claim, find its edges

1. From the MLRS report, note the claim's serial number and claimant.

2. Look up the claim's location notice and map at the **county recorder's office** for that county. Many counties have records online. These show the actual boundaries.
3. In the field, watch for **claim markers**: posts, stacked rocks or pipes, often with a notice in a can or jar. If you see one, assume you're on a claim.
4. Want to pan there anyway? Ask the claimant. Some are happy to let a beginner pan, and many clubs (like local GPAA chapters) own claims their members can use.

The 10-minute checklist

- ☐ Found my spot on a map and wrote down Meridian / Township / Range / Section
- ☐ Ran the Mining Claims – Geographic Report on mlrs.blm.gov with "Active"
- ☐ Checked the neighboring sections too
- ☐ Confirmed the land isn't a national park, wilderness or private land
- ☐ If a claim exists: checked the county recorder or picked another spot
- ☐ Called the BLM field office or ranger district if anything was unclear
- ☐ Wrote it all on my Sample Log page

Ezra says: "In my day you found out a creek was claimed when a fella with a shotgun told you. Your way's better."

This guide is general information, not legal advice. Rules and website layouts change. When in doubt, ask your local BLM field office or Forest Service ranger district. Sources: BLM Mineral & Land Records System (mlrs.blm.gov); BLM Montana-Dakotas Mining Claims Packet; Western Mining History, "Researching Mining Claims with the BLM MLRS".